reactors. Maintaining the speed ordered by Moscow was impossible without surfacing and thus potentially disclosing the presence and location of the submarines. Arkhipov and Savitsky had no choice but to take the risks. According to the recollections of the lead submarine's navigator, Viktor Mikhailov, they "made a decision: proceed by day in RDP mode or using the electric motors at a speed of 6 to 8 knots, and by night under power of three diesel engines at a speed of 14 to 15 knots while recharging the accumulator battery."[7]

While on the surface they could also maintain radio contact with headquarters, but as they moved farther away from the Barents Sea it turned out that the time allocated to them for radio contact, night hours Moscow time, was daytime in the Atlantic. They could communicate with Moscow only while remaining on the surface, in full view of any vessels and planes that happened to be in the area. The Soviet Navy had never undertaken transatlantic submarine raids: Arkhipov's group was pioneering in that regard.

Upon approaching the Sargasso Sea, the submarines encountered a major storm that made surfacing more difficult and slowed down their progress toward Cuba. But the storm also made it easier for them to avoid surveillance, as patrol planes were not flying and the sonar systems of antisubmarine ships could not penetrate the mixed cold and warm layers of ocean water produced by the storm. The subs managed to remain undetected in the Sargasso Sea until October 13, by which time the storm had subsided and water temperature stabilized. On that day sailors on the US Navy tanker *Yukon* observed a surfaced submarine 130 miles north of Caracas. That sighting took place one day before the discovery of medium-range Soviet ballistic missiles in Cuba. Two days later, the submarines would change course.[8]

◊◊◊

ON OCTOBER 15, THE CAPTAINS OF THE SUBMARINES RECEIVED an order from Moscow to abort their movement toward Mariel and take positions in the Sargasso Sea, adopting a condition of four-hour combat readiness. The